



State of Ohio Administrative Policy

Use of Internet, E-mail, and Other IT Resources

No: IT-04

Information Technology

Effective:

April 29, 2025

Issued By:

Kathleen C. Madden, Director

I. Purpose

This state policy establishes controls on the use of state-provided **Information Technology (IT) Resources** to ensure that they are appropriately used for the purposes for which they were acquired. The first occurrence of a defined term in the policy body outside of a title or heading is in bold, italic type, and is hyperlinked to the definition in Section IV.

II. Scope

This policy applies to all state Agencies, boards, and commissions under the authority of the Governor (collectively referred to as Agency or Agencies) and to employees, contractors, temporary personnel and other agents of those Agencies (collectively referred to as Individuals).

III. Policy

Agencies shall establish an **Internet**, e-mail and IT Resources use policy in compliance with this state policy and ensure that Individuals adhere to that policy. Agencies shall define and implement such a policy based on the business requirements of the Agency. Agency policy shall describe the extent to which personal use is allowed. Agencies may adopt or endorse this state policy as Agency policy or may further restrict the duration, frequency and nature of personal use.

- A. **Use of State-Provided IT Resources:** The State of Ohio provides computers, services, software, supplies and other IT Resources to Individuals for supporting the work and

conducting the affairs of Ohio government. Personal use, if permitted by an Agency, shall be strictly limited and can be restricted or revoked at an Agency's discretion at any time.

1. Restrictions on the use of IT Resources outlined in this policy apply to wired and **Wireless** telephone devices and services, including facsimile machines connected to the state's **Telephone Service**. Additional restrictions on the use of state telephones and services are covered by Ohio Administrative Policy IT-11, "Use of State Telephones."
2. In addition to this state policy, collective bargaining contract provisions control the use of state-provided IT Resources for contract enforcement, interpretation and grievance processing.

B. **Unacceptable Personal Use:** Any personal use of IT Resources that disrupts or interferes with government business, incurs an undue cost to the state, could potentially embarrass or harm the state, or has the appearance of impropriety is strictly prohibited. Personal use that is strictly prohibited includes, but is not limited to, the following:

1. Violating or supporting and encouraging the violation of local, state or federal law is strictly prohibited.
2. Downloading, duplicating, disseminating, printing or otherwise using copyrighted materials, such as software, texts, music and graphics, in violation of copyright laws is strictly prohibited.
3. Operating a business, directly or indirectly, for personal gain is strictly prohibited.
4. Accessing or participating in any type of personals advertisements or services, such as or similar to dating services, matchmaking services, companion finding services, pen pal services, escort services, or personals advertisements is strictly prohibited.
5. Downloading, displaying, transmitting, duplicating, storing or printing sexually explicit material is strictly prohibited.
6. Downloading, displaying, transmitting, duplicating, storing or printing material that is offensive, obscene, threatening or harassing is strictly prohibited.
7. Organizing, wagering on, participating in or observing any type of gambling event or activity is strictly prohibited.
8. Sending unsolicited e-mails or facsimiles in bulk or forwarding electronic chain letters in bulk to recipients inside or outside of the state environment is strictly prohibited.
9. Except for Agency-approved efforts, soliciting for money or support on behalf of

charities, religious entities or political causes is strictly prohibited.

- C. **Participation in Online Communities:** Any use of state-provided IT Resources to operate, participate in, access or contribute to an online community including, but not limited to, ***Online Forums, Chat Rooms, Instant Messaging, Listservs, Blogs, Wikis, Peer-to-Peer File Sharing***, and ***Social Media***, is strictly prohibited unless organized or approved by the Agency.
1. If an individual is approved to participate in or access any of these forms of communication as part of state business, that person shall fulfill Agency-defined security education and awareness requirements for proper use before participating.
 2. The content of the education and awareness requirements shall include methods to avoid inadvertent disclosure of ***Confidential Data*** and practices that could harm the security of state computer systems and networks.
 3. Participation in and access to online communities shall align with the State-approved Social Media requirements outlined in Ohio Administrative Policy IT-08, "Website Standardization" and shall be in accordance with Ohio Revised Code Section 125.183 and Executive Order 2023-03D, "Prohibition of Certain Applications, Platforms, and Websites on State-Owned and State-Leased Devices."
- D. **Use of Cloud File Sharing Solutions:** Only state approved ***Cloud File Sharing Solutions***, Microsoft OneDrive for Business and SharePoint Online, shall be used to store, share and synchronize state ***Data***. This requirement is not intended to limit the use of state approved cloud services and solutions. The purpose of the requirement is to prohibit the use of Cloud File Sharing Solutions that are not authorized for state use, that may not be adequately secured and that may compromise the state's ability to preserve and access information and comply with public records laws. When using state approved Cloud File Sharing Solutions, the following restrictions apply:
1. Only Data related to state business shall be stored in state approved Cloud File Sharing Solutions.
 2. Confidential Data shall only be stored in Microsoft OneDrive for Business or SharePoint Online if an Agency has approved the practice. If approved, Agency procedures shall align with the requirements outlined in Ohio Administrative Policy IT-14, "Data Encryption and Securing Confidential Data". Agencies shall ensure that users understand the procedures

for handling and securing Confidential Data. Confidential state Data shall not be downloaded from Cloud File Sharing Solutions onto personal devices unless explicitly authorized by the user's Agency.

3. Any other Cloud File Sharing Solutions shall be submitted to the Department of Administrative Services (DAS) Office of Information Security and Privacy for evaluation and approval prior to being used to share state Data.

E. **Unauthorized Installation or Use of Software:** Installing or using software including, but not limited to, Instant Messaging clients and Peer-to-Peer File Sharing software, or personally owned software, without proper Agency approval is strictly prohibited. Installation and use of unlicensed software is strictly prohibited.

F. **Unauthorized Installation or Use of Hardware:** Installing, attaching, or physically or wirelessly connecting any kind of hardware device to any state-provided IT Resource, including computers and network services, without prior authorization is strictly prohibited. Connecting or attempting to connect a wireless device to the state's wireless service without proper Agency approval is strictly prohibited.

G. **No Expectation of Privacy:** This policy serves as notice to Individuals that they shall have no expectation of privacy in conjunction with their use of state-provided IT Resources.

1. Contents of state computers may be subject to review, investigation, and public disclosure.
2. Access and use of the Internet, including communication by e-mail and Instant Messaging and the content thereof, are not confidential, except in certain limited cases recognized by state or federal law. The state reserves the right to view any files and electronic communications on state computers, monitor and log all electronic activities, and report findings to appropriate supervisors and authorities.
3. Impeding the state's ability to access, inspect and monitor IT Resources is strictly prohibited. Individuals shall not encrypt or conceal the contents of any file or electronic communication on state computers without proper authorization.
4. Individuals shall not set or manipulate a password on any state computer, program, file or electronic communication without proper authorization.

H. **Public Records:** Individuals shall understand that records created as a result of the use of

state-provided IT Resources may be subject to disclosure under Ohio's public records law and must be retained in accordance with state and Agency record retention schedules. In addition, the records created may also be subject to **eDiscovery**.

- I. **Misrepresentation**: Concealing or misrepresenting one's name or affiliation to mask unauthorized, illegal, fraudulent, irresponsible or offensive behavior in electronic communications is strictly prohibited.

- J. **Restrictions on the Use of State E-mail Addresses**: Individuals shall avoid the appearance of impropriety and avoid the appearance of leveraging the stature of the state in the use of their assigned state e-mail address. State e-mail addresses, such as "firstname.lastname@ohio.gov" or "firstname.lastname@Agency.state.oh.us," shall not be used for personal communication in public forums such as, or similar to, Listservs, discussion boards, discussion threads, comment forums, or Blogs.

- K. **Violations of Systems Security Measures**: Any use of state-provided IT Resources that interferes with or compromises the security or operations of any computer system, or compromises public trust, is strictly prohibited.
 - 1. Using IT Resources to violate or attempt to circumvent **Confidentiality** procedures is strictly prohibited.
 - 2. Accessing or disseminating Confidential Data or **Personally Identifiable Information**, without authorization is strictly prohibited.
 - 3. Accessing networks, files or systems or an account of another person without proper authorization is strictly prohibited. Individuals are responsible for safeguarding their passwords.
 - 4. Individuals who are assigned both user accounts and **Privileged User Accounts** shall not use the same password for multiple accounts. Users must maintain unique passwords for each account.
 - 5. Individuals shall not leverage browser-based **Save Password Options**.
 - 6. Distributing **Malicious Code** or circumventing Malicious Code security is strictly prohibited.

- L. **Penalties:** Violation of this policy may result in disciplinary action or contractual penalties and may be cause for termination. In addition, Individuals may be subject to a civil action or criminal prosecution as a result of inappropriate use or misuse of IT Resources. The Ohio Revised Code (ORC) makes certain misuses of IT Resources criminal offenses:
1. ORC Section 2909.04 – knowingly using a computer system, network or the Internet to disrupt or impair a government operation.
 2. ORC Section 2909.05 – causing serious physical harm to property that is owned, leased, or controlled by a government entity.
 3. ORC Section 2913.04 – accessing without authorization any computer, computer system, or computer network without consent of the owner.
 4. ORC Section 2921.41 – using a public office to commit theft which includes fraud and unauthorized use of government computer systems.
- M. **Contractual Agreements:** As of September 14, 2017, any new contractual agreements for vendors and contractors shall include a requirement to comply with this policy as well as any associated Agency policies prior to gaining access to statewide and Agency IT Resources.
- N. **Compliance**
1. Agencies shall undertake measures to ensure that Individuals adhere to Agency policy.
 2. Agencies shall ensure that restrictions and controls on personal use of IT Resources are addressed by education and awareness programs.
 3. Individuals shall be made aware of their respective Agency's use policy, this state policy, applicable local, state and federal laws, and any applicable collective bargaining agreement provisions.
 4. Agencies shall provide Individuals under their employ a copy of the Agency's Internet, e-mail and IT Resources use policy.

IV. Definitions

- A. Availability. Ensuring timely and reliable access to and use of information.¹
- B. Blog. Web-based content consisting primarily of periodic articles or essays listed with the latest entry and visitor comments at the top. Blog topics can range from personal diaries to political issues, media programs and industry analysis. Blogs are also known as “Weblogs” or “Web logs.”
- C. Chat Room. An Online Forum where people can broadcast messages to people connected to the same forum in real time. Sometimes, these forums support audio and video communications, allowing people to converse and to see each other.
- D. Cloud File Sharing Solutions. Cloud services that allow users to store and synchronize documents, photos, videos and other files in the cloud—and share them with other people. These services also allow users to share and synchronize Data among multiple devices for a single owner. These services are accessible through desktops, notebooks, smartphones and media tablets, and provide a simple mechanism for synchronizing Data across multiple devices.²
- E. Confidential Data. This classification includes Data that is required to be protected by law or regulation, is intended for confidential use, and may not be copied or removed from an agency's operational control without authorized permission. This classification includes Data that, if compromised, may result in loss of life, serious injury, or other harm to an individual or group, or disruption to critical agency operations.
- F. Confidentiality. Preserving authorized restrictions on information access and disclosure, including means for protecting personal privacy and proprietary information.³
- G. Data. Coded representation of quantities, objects and actions. The word, “Data,” is often used interchangeably with the word, “information,” in common usage and in this policy.
- H. eDiscovery. “Discovery” refers to the process of complying with legal obligations to produce relevant documents and information to opposing counsel in the course of civil litigation or to

¹ “NIST Special Publication 800-53 Revision 5, Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations,” U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, September 2020. <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.800-53r5.pdf>>.

² “Cloud File Sharing” Gartner IT Glossary. Web. 19 October 2016. <https://www.gartner.com/en/information-technology/glossary/cloud-file-sharing>.

³ “NIST Special Publication 800-53 Revision 5, Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations,” U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, September 2020. <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.800-53r5.pdf>>.

prosecutors or government investigators in criminal or regulatory proceedings. “eDiscovery” refers to the production of files or other Data held in an electronic form, such as e-mail.⁴

- I. Information Technology (IT) Resources. Any Information Technology Resource, such as computer hardware and software, IT services, telecommunications equipment and services, digital devices such as digital copiers and facsimile machines, supplies and the Internet, made available to employees, contractors, temporary personnel and other agents of the state (Individuals) in the course of conducting state government business in support of Agency mission and goals.
- J. Instant Messaging. A software tool that allows real-time electronic messaging or chatting. Instant Messaging services use “presence awareness,” indicating whether people on one’s list of contacts are currently online and available to chat.
- K. Integrity. Guarding against improper information modification or destruction and includes ensuring information non-repudiation and authenticity.⁵
- L. Internet. A worldwide system of computer networks — a network of networks — in which computer users can get information and access services from other computers. The Internet is generally considered to be public, untrusted and outside the boundary of the state of Ohio enterprise network.
- M. Listserv. An electronic mailing list software application that was originally developed in the 1980s and is also known as “discussion lists.” A Listserv subscriber uses the Listserv to send messages to all the other subscribers, who may answer in similar fashion.
- N. Malicious Code. Software or firmware intended to perform an unauthorized process that will have adverse impacts on the Confidentiality, **Integrity**, or **Availability** of an information system. Some examples include a virus, worm, Trojan horse, or other code-based entity that infects a host. Spyware and some forms of adware are also examples of Malicious Code.⁶
- O. Online Forum. A Web application where people post messages on specific topics. Forums are also known as Web forums, message boards, discussion boards and discussion groups.
- P. Peer-to-Peer (P2P) File Sharing. Directly sharing content like audio, video, Data, software or anything in digital format between any two computers connected to the network without the need for a central server.

⁴ Jamie Popkin, “E-Discovery for IT Professionals: An Exceptional Process that Requires Unique Core Competencies,” Gartner Research Note, 17 February 2011 (Stamford, CT: Gartner, Inc., 2011).

⁵ “NIST Special Publication 800-53 Revision 5, Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations,” U.S. Department of Commerce National Institute of Standards and Technology, September 2020. <<https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/SpecialPublications/NIST.SP.800-53r5.pdf>>.

⁶ *Ibid.*

- Q. Personally Identifiable Information (PII). “Personally Identifiable Information” is information that can be used directly or in combination with other information to identify a particular individual. It includes:
- a name, identifying number, symbol, or other identifier assigned to a person,
 - any information that describes anything about a person,
 - any information that indicates actions done by or to a person,
 - any information that indicates that a person possesses certain personal characteristics.⁷
- R. Privileged User Accounts. Passwords associated with user accounts, which are assigned to individuals (commonly referred to as named accounts), that have elevated access to make changes to system parameters.
- S. Save Password Option. An option on some systems that, when enabled, allows the user the choice of whether to have the user password memorized by the system so that it will not need to be re-entered upon subsequent access.
- T. Social Media. Refers to an online environment or application that facilitates user participation, networking, and collaboration through the submission of user generated content. In general, this includes tools such as: Blogs, Wikis, microblogging sites, social networks, video sharing sites, and bookmarking sites.
- U. Telephone Service. Unless otherwise stated, Telephone Service includes both wired telephones and wireless telephones.
- V. Wiki. A Web application that allows one user to add content and any other user to edit the content. The popular software used to implement this type of Web collaboration is known as “Wiki.” A well-known implementation is Wikipedia, an online encyclopedia.
- W. Wireless. Use of various electromagnetic spectrum frequencies, such as radio and infrared, to communicate services, such as Data and voice, without relying on a hardwired connection, such as twisted pair, coaxial or fiber optic cable.

V. Authority

ORC 125.18, 125.183
Executive Order 2023-03D

⁷ Based on Ohio Revised Code Section 1347.01 (E).

VI. Resources

None

VII. Inquiries

Direct inquiries about this policy to:

State IT Policy Manager
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
30 East Broad Street, 39th Floor
Columbus, Ohio 43215

1-614-644-6860 | DAS.State.ITPolicy.Manager@das.ohio.gov

State of Ohio Administrative Policies may be found online at
<https://das.ohio.gov/technology-and-strategy/policies>

Direct inquiries regarding Confidential Data and Cloud File Sharing Solutions to:

Office of Information Security & Privacy
Office of Information Technology
Ohio Department of Administrative Services
30 East Broad Street, 19th Floor
Columbus, Ohio 43215

1-614-644-9391 | state.isp@das.ohio.gov

VIII. Revision History

This policy shall be reviewed no less than every two years and updated as needed.

Date	Description of Change
01/01/1996	Ohio IT Policy OPP-008 replaces PB-002 and all previously released memoranda regarding this topic.
03/20/2006	Revise policy requirements on acceptable and unacceptable personal use of IT Resources by Individuals.
03/19/2008	Policy requirements concerning participation in online communities were moved from ITP-B.6, "Internet Security," into section 2.3 of this policy.
04/18/2011	References to Ohio IT Policies ITP-B.3, "Password and PIN Security," and ITP-B.4, "Malicious Code Security," were removed from the policy. These policies were rescinded due to the publication of Ohio IT Standard ITS-SEC-02, "Enterprise Security Controls Framework."
05/04/2015	Added requirements for the use of cloud storage solutions and eDiscovery as well as modified the public records and record retention section. Transferred policy content to a new State of Ohio Administrative Policy Template. Re-numbered policy to IT-04 to be consistent with the new numbering format.
09/14/2017	Revised the cloud storage solution requirements to align with current capabilities and procedures. The focus of the requirements is now on Cloud File Sharing Solutions. Added new requirements for passwords and vendor/contractor contractual agreements.
01/15/2020	Updated the policy template to align with the current format.
10/13/2021	Conducted routine maintenance review of citations and references.
01/09/2023	Included a reference to Executive Order 2023-03D Prohibition of Certain Applications, Platforms, and Websites on State-Owned and State-Leased Devices and Ohio Administrative Policy IT-08, "Website Standardization," State-approved Social Media channel requirements. Modified revision history review frequency statement and updated policy branding. Removed the state registry requirement and procedures section that required the submission of Agency Internet, e-mail and IT Resources use policies to DAS OIT. Modified the contractual agreements portion of the policy to clarify the effective date of the requirement.

Date	Description of Change
10/03/2023	Added a reference to ORC 125.183 and modified the definition of social media. Modified the save password options requirement. Updated the policy template.
04/29/2025	Replaced the term sensitive data, or sensitive information, with confidential data. Revised reference to Ohio Administrative Policy IT-14 to reflect the title change.